

my assistant to pull up news or sports channels he needs to watch.

The Patchwall+ is another feature we quite like. It aims to replicate a DTH-like interface to which many people cutting the chord are already accustomed. Once again, this is a useful edition for my parents who'd rather flick channels and watch whatever is currently on air. The problem is that the supported channels in my preferred languages are very limited. Xiaomi will hopefully fix these issues in time.

SDR PICTURE QUALITY

Let's first look into the SDR picture quality, given that a significant portion of desi content still remains in this format. Right off the bat, we could notice that Xiaomi's vivid colour engine is tuned for extra pop and not for strict colour accuracy.

For SDR content, the standard mode is the best available choice. Other modes including the Movie preset introduce an annoying reddish tint to skin tones while exaggerating colours to extreme.

To test the TV, we used Spectral C6 HDR2000 colorimeter along with Portrait Display's Calman Ultimate software. The standard mode has slightly cooler whites than the reference and slightly oversaturated colours. By setting the colour gamut to rec.709 and gamma to 1886, we managed an average delta error of 6, which is not the lowest we have recorded but still fairly decent. The panel can reproduce 99.9% of the sRGB colour gamut used in SDR content. For those less concerned about strict colour accuracy, the added vibrancy in colours during daylight and well-lit indoor scenes could be appealing.

The gamma tracks below the standard towards higher luminance. This implies that certain details in brighter regions might not be as pronounced. Nevertheless, this wasn't glaringly apparent in our assessment of bright SDR scenes during testing. We also didn't notice any oversharpening on the TV with default settings in the standard mode.

We recorded a native panel contrast of around 1250:1 in the Standard mode, and this is further enhanced with Global Dimming enabled. The upscaling performance for SDR content was above average as compared to other similarly priced options that we have tested.

Motion smoothening is enabled in all SDR and HDR presets save for Dolby Vision HDR. This does reduce motion blur in slow panning shots but induces a slight stutter and soap opera effect. We'd recommend that you turn it off or reduce the smoothening in the custom mode.

HDR PERFORMANCE

The Xiaomi X-series Smart TV boasts support for Dolby Vision, HDR10 and HLG formats. In terms of peak brightness, we registered a measurement of 375 nits, a standard figure when compared to affordable and lower mid-range television models. Observing the EOTF tracking curve, it's clear that Xiaomi has fine-tuned the TV to maximize HDR impact using available dynamic range stops.

The TV follows the PQ transfer function for HDR more diligently with global dimming turned on. It slightly over tracks the EOTF curve in the brighter region, leading to some compromise in bright highlight details.

Challenges with skin tones persist in Dolby Vision content. In Dolby Vision, light skin tones exhibit a pinkish tint. These anomalies are more noticeable in dark scenes where characters are illuminated by warm sources like fire or lanterns. Despite this, the colours of the sky and foliage appear natural in Dolby Vision content.

In HDR10, the skin tones once again feel a little unnatural and colours are also a tad oversaturated. We recorded an average delta error of 6.8.

We recorded a BT2020 colour volume of 68.53% in UV terms, which is above average in the price segment.

So, overall, the HDR presentation of the TV is a mixed bag.

GAMING AND AUDIO

The TV appeared quite responsive while

gaming. The colours in game mode are once again a little vivid, but this didn't bother us much while playing games. HDMI 2.1 features like ALLM can help you quickly switch to game mode with latest consoles. Since Xiaomi is using a 60Hz panel, full HDMI 2.1 bandwidth isn't required.

The TV comes with a 30W audio system with Dolby Audio, DTS X and DTS Virtual: X. The audio system gets loud enough to fill an average-sized living room. Dialogues in movies were clear in the default preset. For a decent surround sound experience, you will have to invest in a soundbar or any other external audio system.

VERDICT

Overall, the Xiaomi Smart TV X Series (2023) doesn't strike as an extraordinary option but it offers fairly decent value and should deliver a decent content viewing experience for most people. The spotlight feature is Xiaomi's Patchwall and Patchwall+ services which are easy to navigate and make it simpler to discover content. With the arrival of several new brands, the Indian TV market is now replete with options.

Indian manufacturers do have several affordable 65-inch options under different licensed brands like Kodak, Nu, and Acer that might not offer as many features but are available at lower prices and are worth considering for those seeking affordable 65-inch options.

—Deepak Singh

SPECIFICATIONS

Panel Size: 65-inch (available in 43, 50, and 55-inch as well) | Panel Type: LED LCD | Panel Resolution: 3840 x 2160 - 4K UHD | Panel Refresh Rate: 60Hz | Supported HDR Formats: HDR10, Dolby Vision | Speakers: 30W | Audio formats: Supports Dolby Audio, DTS X and DTS Virtual: X | Software: Google TV, Latest PatchWall, PatchWall+ | Free Live TV Channels | HDMI Ports: 3x HDMI 2.1, HDMI 2 is eARC | HDMI 2.1 features - eARC, ALLM | Other connectivity options: 2 USB ports, Wi-Fi 5, Bluetooth 5, Ethernet, RF connection input, Headphone out, optical input | Built-in storage: 8GB

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